

“I Can Talk to AI, but the Making Is Mine” Professional Artists’ Use of Generative Agents for Creative Work

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Abstract

Survey research finds that professional visual artists overwhelmingly dislike generative AI, yet many encounter it in their working lives. We interviewed five professional visual artists working across physical and digital media about where in the creative process they use a generative agent, how they use it, and why they use it in some phases and not others. We mapped the interviews onto the four phases of Mace and Ward’s model of the creative process. Participants used the agent only for gathering information within artwork conception and for developing ideas, and they kept idea conception, making, and finishing to themselves, citing authorship, craft, and the fear of feeding the model. We offer this account as a record of how professional artists place a generative agent while capabilities and norms are still taking shape.

CCS Concepts

• Human-centered computing → Empirical studies in HCI.

Keywords

generative AI, professional artists, creative work

1 Introduction

Generative AI is entering professional creative work over the objections of many artists [2, 5]. In one survey of 378 professional visual artists, 99% reported disliking it, and 85% never use it in their work [3]. Research on AI in creative work focuses on the rejection itself, co-creation at the interface, or adoption under pressure [1, 4, 7]. From our understanding, much less is known about professional artists who do let a generative agent in, where they allow it to operate, how, and why. We focus on placement, on where within a practice the agent is admitted and where it is refused, phase by phase. Mace and Ward’s model [6] gives those phases a shared structure, so placements can be compared across practices.

We interviewed five professional visual artists working across physical and digital media, asking three questions. **RQ1:** in which phases of the creative process do professional visual artists use a generative agent? **RQ2:** how do they use it in each phase? **RQ3:** why do they use it in some phases and not others?

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In our analysis, we mapped participants’ reported uses against the four phases of Mace and Ward’s model of the creative process [6]: artwork conception, idea development, making the artwork, and finishing the artwork. Participants used the agent to find references and sources, organize their ideas, generate visual references, and explore directions within their own style.

This study provides a qualitative account of where, how, and why five professional artists use a generative agent in their creative process. Two placements stand out. Participants admitted the agent into gathering information but refused it in conceiving the idea, and the reasons they gave mostly concerned authorship, craft, and protection from training, not the agent’s capability.

2 Method

Participants were recruited through art forums, personal networks, and snowball sampling. Eligibility required self-identifying as a professional visual artist, defined as making a living from the work [3], and using generative AI in at least one part of their work. Participant information is shown in Table 1.

Table 1: Participant information.

ID	Gender	Media	Years	Gen AI use
P1	Female	Physical	3-4 years	Daily
P2	Male	Both	3-4 years	Daily
P3	Female	Physical	1-2 years	3-4 times a week
P4	Male	Physical	<1 year	3-4 times a week
P5	Female	Digital	3-4 years	3-4 times a week

Each participant completed a 60-minute video interview covering their practice, where generative AI appears in it, and how they think about authorship and ownership. Interviews were semi-structured, with follow-up probes on each use participants described. Interviews were recorded and transcribed in full with informed consent. Transcripts were analyzed through iterative team thematic analysis: each author coded transcripts at sentence level, and codes were consolidated into a shared codebook across team meetings.

3 Findings

3.1 Where They Use the Agent

We located the reported uses within the four phases of Mace and Ward’s model in Figure 1. Every use fell within the first two, artwork conception and idea development. Within artwork conception, participants separated the idea itself from the information gathered around it, and the agent appeared only in the latter.

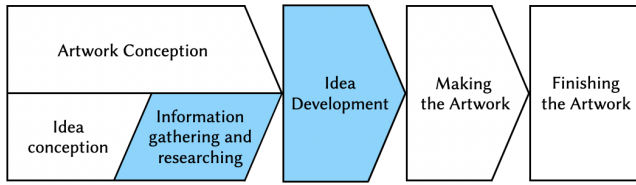


Figure 1: The four phases of Mace and Ward's model of the creative process [6]. Blue marks participants' agent use.

3.1.1 Artwork Conception.

Information gathering and researching. While conceiving a work, participants gathered outside information: technical, scholarly, or legal. They described this as searching rather than thinking. P1 put the distinction plainly, “I rely on AI to search for things instead of using it to think for me,” treating the agent, “like a library, so it doesn’t have a personal thought at all.”

How. Participants used the agent here for references and sources. P3 searched for materials information, “asking how to make materials more solid”, then tested what came back, “I try making samples based on its recommendations, and some products definitely work.” P1 used the agent to find scholarly sources rather than digest them, “I found some papers while searching with AI, and when I found them, I read them myself.”

Why. Participants gave two practical reasons, filling gaps in their expertise and saving time before the work begins. P3 stated, “I’m an expert in art but not an expert in art materials, so I want to do that research through AI.” Saving time also mattered, and P2, in their work, “used AI because I’m not familiar with all the legal framework, so I’ve saved time not reading so many books.”

3.1.2 Idea Development. Participants who used the agent here brought it ideas that already existed and worked on them in text. P4 described the loop, “I attached my paintings to AI, and based on my previous works it gave me further directions as a textual response. After reading the text, I create another sketch.”

How. Participants used the agent in three ways, talking through their own thoughts, generating quick visual options, and synthesizing from their own material, and in every case they filtered what it returned. For the first, P4 had conversations with the agent, where they, “only write questions to AI and get textual responses,” and used the agent for organizing, “AI can help me organize [my thoughts] step by step.” The second was rapid visual conceptualization. In commercial projects, P5 generates options early, “It’s usually used in the first stage: conceptualize, sample, fast turnarounds, ‘create me eight different symbols,’” and holds the results at reference status, “We can reference it, but I wouldn’t use it as a final project.” For the third, P5 explained, “I’d bring in my own artwork and whatever look I want, mix it, and run it through AI.” Whatever form the exchange took, participants filtered what came back. P4 takes, “certain responses from it selectively.”

Why. Participants pointed beyond their own perspective. P1: “When I think by myself, it can be like looking only at your own things, but with AI you get everyone’s thoughts combined into one, so you learn about another perspective.” P5 valued the reach, “it helps me

think outside the box and gives me options I hadn’t thought of, so I get to look around and see what I’ve missed.”

3.2 Where They Do Not Use the Agent

3.2.1 Artwork Conception.

Idea conception. Participants described the idea itself as coming without the agent. P4’s work is “based on original thoughts and what comes to my mind, worked out through sketching and photography”.

Why. The reasons concerned ownership of the concept and protection of it. For P1, the concept decides whose work it is, “if you don’t think of the concept, it’s not your work.” P4 made the same demand of themselves, “You have to know what you want to do, what you want to create and express.” P2’s reason was protection. They would not show the agent a new sketch: “I’m afraid it will steal my idea. I don’t want to train the model.”

3.2.2 Making the Artwork. All five participants described making as work they do themselves. For P3, “the idea and all the brush strokes are coming from me.”

Why. Each participant grounded the refusal differently: in originality, in craft identity, in the value of labor, and in what manual making alone secures. P4 saw generation as both copying and devaluing, “I won’t ask AI to generate the actual image, because then I’d be copying from AI,” and, “If it’s completely generated by AI, then it somehow devalues the work.” P5’s reason was craft identity, “I consider myself more of a craftsmanship-type person, so I’d rather do it myself,” P1’s was the difference labor makes, “human work and labor are different from just pressing a button,” and P2’s was what manual work secures, “you have something they can never get.”

3.2.3 Finishing the Artwork. Participants said the least about this phase, describing it as the point where the work is resolved and leaves the studio. For this phase, P3 stated, “I’m not sure I’ll use this [AI] approach in the future [...] if it feels insecure, I won’t.”

Why. Participants kept the agent out of finished work because its output falls short of final quality, because finished work can be taken up as training data, and because the handmade object holds value of its own. For P5, the output is not final-grade, “for conceptualizing it’s quick and nice, but for final production I’m still not satisfied.” For P2, finished work is withheld from models, “I started making collage before the emergence of AI. Still, knowing that AI can be trained from your works does push me, to some degree, toward physical artifacts or projects.” And P4 observed that, “people appreciate handmade things more.”

4 Discussion and Conclusion

Across five professional practices, the generative agent was admitted only where it fed the artist’s own thinking, in the information gathering within artwork conception and in idea development. The idea itself, the making, and the finishing stayed with the artist, held back by authorship, craft, and the fear of feeding the model. Our findings offer a close account of five practices at a formative moment, documenting where professional artists draw these placements while capabilities and norms are still taking shape. Future work could examine whether this pattern, including the split inside artwork conception, recurs across larger and more varied professional populations.

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